

A Taste of Home: How OU's Asian Community Has Grown — and What Still Needs to Change

Asian students at the University of Oklahoma say campus feels more welcoming than it did decades ago, but many still struggle to find a true sense of home.

When Faye Evans arrived at OU in 1983, she and a small group of Taiwanese students drove to Oklahoma City every few weeks to buy groceries. Norman didn't have an Asian market then, and it still doesn't today. They bought rice, vegetables and sauces in bulk, then returned to campus to cook together.

"It was the only way to feel like home," Evans said. "Food connects people."

Today, Oklahoma City's Asian District is a well-known cultural hub, and OU's campus hosts food fairs, cultural nights and holiday celebrations that draw students from many backgrounds. The difference between Evans' experience and today's community shows how much has changed — and what still needs work.

Evans found comfort in the Chinese Student Association, which was almost entirely Taiwanese at the time. She rarely met Asian students from other backgrounds and said the group felt like "a little, little world... just us." There were few cultural events and little visibility on campus.

The Asian American Student Association, founded in 1985, helped broaden that community. According to its ENGAGE page, AASA's mission is to promote Asian American cultural awareness and create a welcoming space for students. President Farsid Islam said that mission remains central.

"Our main goal is to spread Asian American cultural awareness and create a place where people feel comfortable," Islam said.

AASA now hosts monthly meetings and major events like the Asian Food Fair and Lunar New Year. But Islam said the group still faces limits, including the loss of its former office. "A dedicated space made people feel at home," he said. "Losing that hurt."

Another sign of change is the return of the Chinese Student Association. The new CSA, led by president Alayna Leck, is the first true CSA at OU.

"I want CSA to become a home," Leck said. "Somewhere you walk in and feel welcome."

For students like Makiyah Joseph, who is Vietnamese and Black, belonging comes from finding spaces that accept every part of their identity. Her multicultural sorority became that place. “They never made me feel lesser for being different,” she said.

Compared to the 1980s, OU’s Asian community is larger, more diverse and more active. But students say they still want a dedicated cultural space, more funding and year-round support. Evans said seeing today’s community gives her hope.

“So many different kinds of people,” she said. “So much culture.”

SOURCE LIST

Human Sources

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Informational Sources

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Asian American Student Association — OU ENGAGE page

Organizational mission, purpose and background

URL: <https://ou.campuslabs.com/engage/organization/asian-american-student-association>